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Career Development for Exceptional Individuals 2011 34: 31
DOI: 10.1177/0885728811399277

Hammill Institute on Disabilities

Career Development for Exceptional Individuals
34(1) 31–44

DOI: 10.1177/0885728811399277
http://cdei.sagepub.com
SAGE

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Abstract

Students with intellectual disabilities are taking the lead conducting participatory action research (PAR) to chronicle their college experience as part of a national college access initiative. This research currently involves college students with intellectual disabilities documenting their experiences using multimedia tools. These data are then shared via a digital storytelling website, VoiceThread. This article presents an overview of PAR, digital storytelling, and the methodology used to implement PAR with students with intellectual disabilities. Themes from the students' work highlight their impressions of college, their adjustment to new expectations and responsibilities, and their recommendations to improve this experience. The researcher's findings and conclusions about facilitating research with young adults with intellectual disabilities are described.

Keywords

participatory action research, students with intellectual disabilities, postsecondary education

As a result of advocacy, policy development, and innovative collaboration among key stakeholders, students with intellectual disabilities (ID) now have opportunities to extend their education to college (Grigal & Hart, 2010; Hart, Grigal, Sax, Martinez, & Will, 2006; Lee & Will, 2010). This pioneering access to postsecondary education has gained momentum by applying universal design principles in higher education settings (Behling & Hart, 2008; Silver, Bourke, & Strehorn, 1998), adopting supported education models (Mowbray et al., 2005), and developing nontraditional pathways to enroll and matriculate in college (Grigal, Dwyre, & Davis, 2006; Hart, Zafft, & Zimbrich, 2001). Given these approaches in creating college access and participation, it is logical that students with ID have equally accessible, supported, and nontraditional methods to evaluate their college experiences. These methods include designing research protocols and materials in easy-to-understand language, using action research strategies, adapting data collection procedures with digital technology, and emphasizing research collaboration with participants over time (Mactavish, Mahon, & Lutviyya, 2000; O'Brien et al., 2009; Paiewonsky, 2005). In applying these alternative research methods, stakeholders are more likely to collect authentic student data that illuminate how college access strategies are influencing students' postsecondary education experiences.

Over the past 10 years, an expanding number of colleges and universities in the United States have developed postsecondary education opportunities for students identified as having ID (Hart et al., 2006). In large part, this is the result of increasing interest from students themselves who have experienced more inclusive educational opportunities in K–12 settings as well as their parents' advocacy for continued educational opportunities (Grigal & Hart, 2010). Hart et al. (2006) describe three general postsecondary education models that are developed for students with ID. In the first model, the mixed-hybrid model, students participate in social and academic activities with students without disabilities. They typically take classes with other students with disabilities but may enroll in some courses open to all students. Students may have jobs on or off campus. In the second model, the inclusive individual support model, students take courses along with their peers without disabilities. They enroll in courses related to their career goals and work with an interagency team to find paid work that aligns with their career vision. A third model is referred to as a substantially separate model. In this case, students are on the campus and may be involved in nonacademic campus activities open to the entire student body. However, they take classes with other students with disabilities. Their course of study includes specially designed curriculum and instruction, usually focused on functional academics, rotating employment experiences, and daily living skills.

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To access one of these postsecondary education models, Hart, Grigal, and Weir (2010) suggest three paths that students with ID may take to higher education. The first pathway, the dual or concurrent enrollment model, is often initiated by a school system. High schools support students ages 18 through 21 years old through Individuals with Disabilities Education Act–funded special education transition services to access college in their final years of transitional activities. Ideally, students are able to access a full range of courses but may be directed to college courses with noncredit status, courses without prerequisites, or remedial courses. A second path, college initiated programs, is often developed with adult agencies and is aimed at adult students with ID. Secondary school support is not available. Course access resembles the dual or concurrent enrollment model. The third path is individual- or family-initiated supports. In this model, individuals and families initiate college opportunities on their own. With support from their families, individuals may apply through the standard admissions process or may try to broker access to courses through disability services or a specific instructor.

Currently, the literature and dissemination materials related to postsecondary education for individuals with ID focus on promoting the rationale for developing postsecondary education opportunities (Hughson, Moodie, & Uditsky, 2006; Lee & Will, 2010; Neubert & Moon, 2006) and the policies and practices needed to sustain these efforts (Getzel & Wehman, 2005; Grigal & Hart, 2010). The existing evaluation literature focuses primarily on perceptions of college faculty and disability services staff (Rao, 2004; Salzberg et al., 2002) and parents (Grigal, Neubert, & Moon, 2002). There is little evidence of studies where students themselves assessed their college experience in their own words. One exception is a study from Ireland, in which students with ID reported on their college experience (O'Brien et al., 2009). In this study, students participated in focus groups and were invited to participate in Photovoice (Wang & Burris, 1997), an action research method in which participants take photographs highlighting strengths and challenges of their experiences. For this study, students took photos illustrating how their identities as learners changed, how they perceived their tutors, their growth as self-advocates, and friendships they developed (O'Brien et al., 2009). Findings demonstrated how college was affecting the lives of students with ID both academically and personally in ways traditional methods might overlook.

Some advocates would argue that colleges already collect information on students enrolled at their postsecondary institutions. In fact, there are a number of existing national studies that capture experiences and perceptions of college students. Among these annual surveys are Your First College Year (Ruiz, Sharkness, Kelley, DeAngleo, & Pryor, 2010), the National Survey of Student Engagement (NSSE, 2009), the Community College Survey of Student Engagement (Center for Community College Student Engagement [CCCSC], 2009), and The American Freshman: National Norms (Pryor, Hurtado, DeAngelo, Palucki Blake, & Tran, 2009). These surveys encapsulate important information about students' connections with faculty and peers, their satisfaction with courses, their study habits, their participation in activities on and off campus, and how their expectations of college have been met. With this information, colleges are able to target specific areas of need such as promoting better relationships between students and faculty using technology (CCCSC, 2009), reducing bureaucratic college procedures that discourage students from enrolling in courses (NSSE, 2009), and promoting college for first-generation college students who are considering college (Higher Education Research Institute [HERI], 2010; Pryor et al., 2010). However these studies do not specifically reflect the perspectives of students with disabilities, including students with ID. These perspectives are absent because students with ID either are not enrolled as full-time students (HERI, 2009), which is an eligibility requirement to complete several of the surveys, or do not attend one of the 4-year or 2-year colleges that participate in these nationwide studies. Even national surveys that collect information on college students with disabilities do not include information on students with ID (Grigal & Hart, 2010).

In addition to being omitted from national studies, individuals with ID who do participate in research activities report several logistical challenges, including (a) not fully understanding the content or purpose of the research, (b) having materials (consent forms and surveys) read aloud as an accommodation (which is not always the best format to absorb research information), (c) limited transportation options to engage in research activities that are designed to be participatory and ongoing, and (d) feeling that their opinions are ignored by professionals (Heller, Pederson, & Miller, 1996). Finlay and Lyons (2002) reported researchers contributed to barriers by developing interview questions that were too complex, ill constructed, or too abstract. Even studies designed to encourage direct engagement of individuals with ID come with challenges. Specifically, K. Ward and Trigler (2001) found that when using a participatory action research (PAR) model promoting collaboration at all phases of the research process, asking participants to engage in the data analysis and interpretation phases of the research was difficult. In particular, they found participants had a hard time extrapolating beyond their own experiences to analyze the meaning of data for a representative group.

As a result, there is growing interest in finding ways to emphasize students with disabilities' engagement in postsecondary education research (deFur & Korineck, 2008; Fogg & Harrington, 2009; Neubert & Redd, 2008; Webb, Patterson, Syveurd, & Seabrooks-Blackmore, 2008). In addition, there is an expectation from self-advocacy groups that organizations implement authentic research methods that include individuals with ID as coresearchers (Administration on Developmental Disabilities, 2006; Rose & Shevlin, 2004; Valade, 2008; Walmsley & Johnson, 2003; K. Ward & Trigler, 2001; L. Ward & Townsley, 2005; Zarb, 1992). The following recommendations have been made to make research more inclusive: (a) teaching participants about the research process (Valade, 2008; K. Ward & Trigler, 2001), (b) using plain language (Heller et al., 1996), (c) using multiple and intensive data collection strategies (Mactavish et al., 2000), (d) presuming participants' credibility (Mactavish et al., 2000; Tregaskis & Goodley, 2005), (e) developing easy-to-understand approaches to seek informed consent (Heller et al., 1996), and (f) producing dissemination materials that are universally accessible and meaningful (Board Resource Center, 2005; Tarleton, 2005; Tierney, Curtis, & O'Brien, 2009; Walmsley & Johnson, 2003).

What is missing from the literature is any evidence that students with ID have the opportunity to critically evaluate their college experience with research methods that seek to gain a full understanding of how their expectations are or are not being met. Without this information, policy makers and practitioners will continue to develop postsecondary education initiatives for students with ID that may not meet their unique needs. Designing research methods with college students with ID that are accessible and meaningful to them has the potential to enable them to influence and even control research that is focused on their lives.

Therefore, this study was designed to promote the voice of college students with ID by asking them to document and assess their college experiences with digital media tools. Students were also asked to make recommendations to improve this experience for themselves and others. This PAR focused on two research questions:

1. How do students with ID who have taken at least one college class describe their experiences in inclusive concurrent enrollment activities?
2. What recommendations do students with ID suggest to improve the college experience for themselves and others?

Method

In searching for a research method to promote active engagement of students with ID, PAR was selected because of its grounding in engaging individuals with stories to tell about their lives and its flexible format. PAR is an emancipatory and cyclical form of research that promotes collaboration between researchers and participants. Over the past 15 years, there has been an increasing interest by community-based researchers to use PAR as a method to enable people to tell stories that help them to interpret their lives (Ferguson, Ferguson, & Taylor, 1992; Stringer, 2007). Research facilitators who adopt community-based action research practices put aside traditional research protocols that typically assume researchers will determine questions, employ survey tools, and document what will be the valued outcomes (Minkler & Wallerstein, 2003). Instead, community-based researchers use action research methods that value what individuals want to share about their lives and experiences and, more importantly, value the telling of the story (Ferguson et al., 1992). It is through these stories that sometimes assumptions about individuals or their experiences are contradicted, shedding light on more authentic perceptions (Taylor, Bogdan, & Lutfiyya, 1995).

PAR With Individuals With ID

Evidence suggests that PAR methods have been successful in promoting the voice of individuals with ID to discuss issues that affect their lives including their health status (Jurkowski & Paul-Ward, 2008), circles of support and how those supports influence transition outcomes (Stevenson, 2007), transportation concerns (Valade, 2008), social integration (Mactavish et al., 2000), self-advocacy (Garcia-Iriarte, Kramer, Kramer, & Hammel, 2009), and quality of life issues (K. Ward & Trigler, 2001). In addition, PAR is a flexible process that does not dictate one particular strategy, only that the strategies employed promote the personal involvement of those affected by the research endeavor (Valade, 2008). Using action research throughout all phases of this study promotes (a) authentic data; (b) a comparison of the data generated with existing postsecondary education knowledge, training materials, and dissemination strategies; and (c) development of additional training and technical assistance materials to address barriers and gaps.

PAR Tools and Strategies

Given the flexibility of PAR, the researcher selected two strategies to promote easy access to data collection as well as student reflection about their inclusive college experiences. First, the research facilitator asked students to use digital cameras and pocket video cameras to gather their information. By using these visual and audio tools, students were offered an opportunity to develop and share data that were accessible to them, their peers, and their research collaborators (Tarleton, 2005; Tierney et al., 2009; L. Ward & Townsley, 2005). Second, a web-based digital storytelling application called VoiceThread (http://voicethread.com, 2007) was used as a strategy to provide students with a place to share, discuss, and analyze their data. In every case, principles of universal design and plain language were adopted to ensure access (Plain Language Action and Information

Network, 2005; Tarleton, 2005; Tierney et al., 2009; L. Ward & Townsley, 2005; Zambo, 2009).

Digital storytelling is a multimedia methodology used for both case study and personal narrative inquiry (Lambert, 2006). By combining the elements of storytelling with visual and audio technologies, digital storytelling allows participants to generate and use their own data to convey personal experiences (Collier & Collier, 1986; Makagon & Neuman, 2009; Pink, 2007; Wang, 1999). Since a tenet of digital storytelling is to elicit the tensions and emotions of an experience, stories draw listeners into meaningful and effective statements about individual lives (Lambert, 2006; Solinger, Fox, & Irani, 2008).

Student Recruitment

Participants in this study were recruited from a group of college students with ID who participated in the Massachusetts Inclusive Concurrent Enrollment (ICE) initiative, a statewide concurrent enrollment model that began in 2007. The initiative involves partnerships between seven community colleges and 30 school districts and is administered by the Massachusetts Department of Elementary and Secondary Education in collaboration with the Department of Higher Education with funds appropriated by the state legislature. To participate in the ICE initiative, students must meet the following criteria: (a) be between the ages of 18 and 21, (b) be eligible for special education services from their school districts, and (c) not meet the local requirements for a high school diploma. Since students participating in this initiative are still eligible for special education services while attending college, their status is referred to as "concurrently enrolled students." The ICE initiative is based on the inclusive individual support model (Hart et al., 2001; Hart et al., 2006). In this state initiative, the model promoted students in participating in person-centered planning to identify career interests and goals, enroll in related inclusive college courses that support those interests, and work with an interagency team to secure employment based on their career goals.

Researcher as Facilitator

To promote and sustain engagement of participants, the researcher assumed the role of research facilitator. In this position, the research facilitator (a) established and encouraged relationships among all participants, (b) promoted effective communication strategies and supports, (c) enabled productive work from all members, and (d) ensured that all members benefit from the process (Stringer, 2007; Wadsworth, 2006). In working with students with ID who had little background in research activities, the research facilitator took an active role in finding ways to make the research process accessible and meaningful for the students.

Recruiting and Meeting With Student Researchers

The research facilitator invited two to three students from each of the ICE partnerships to be researchers. The only criterion used was that students had completed at least one full semester of college so they could comment on the whole experience. Students at two of the colleges were unable to participate because of their schedules and other commitments. However, a total of nine students from four colleges did accept the invitation and consented to coresearch their postsecondary education experiences. As outlined in Table 1, student researchers (from here on referred to as students) ranged in age from 19 to 21 years old. They had been involved in the ICE initiative from two to five semesters. Four students were male and five were female. One student was African American, one was African, two were Asian American, and five were Caucasian. Two students lived in large urban cities, two lived in suburban cities, and the remaining five lived in rural communities. As for their concurrent enrollment status, students were enrolled in a variety of college classes, either 2 or 3 days a week, and participated in college activities such as using the fitness facilities, hanging out at the library or student center, and meeting with a tutor. Classes ranged from career oriented to fitness and performance courses. Two students had paid jobs in the community. The other seven students worked at unpaid internships, arranged by high school staff, when they were not on the college campus. Seven of the eight students were required to attend school in self-contained classrooms during school hours when they were not at work and not at college. One student followed a flexible, community-based schedule and was not required to return to the high school.

The research facilitator met with each student one to two times a month during the spring and fall semester of 2009. Although the meeting locations varied, based on the convenience for the students, the majority of meetings were held at colleges that students attended.

Data Collection and Analyses

Various data were collected for the research facilitator including students' images and video clips, their narratives and stories, and the research facilitators' field notes and photographs. These methods were adopted because growing evidence in the field of disability perspective research indicates that multiple and intensive data collection strategies are necessary when one presumes that the perspectives of people with ID are credible and valuable (Biklen & Moseley, 1988; Bogdan & Biklen, 1992; Cinamon & Gifsh, 2004; Mactavish et al., 2000; Taylor & Bogdan, 1998) and are revealed over time (Paiewonsky, 2005). Given the amount of data that were collected, identifying a process to organize and examine relationships among concepts that emerged from the study was

Table 1. Student Researchers for Think College

Student, Age	Ethnicity	Community	Concurrent Enrollment Status		Courses Taken
			School Status	College Status	
Student 1, Age 21	Asian American	Suburban	Self-contained class, unpaid internship in community	Community college 2 days a week	Career and Life Planning, Microsoft Word
Student 2, Age 21	Asian American	Suburban	Self-contained class, unpaid internship in community	Community college 3 days a week	Career and Life Planning, English, Anatomy and Physiology, Introduction to Business, Introduction to Marketing
Student 3, Age 20	African	Urban	Self-contained class, unpaid internship in community	Community college 3 days a week	Intro to College/Career, Fundamentals of Art, Home Health Aide orientation, Intro to Word Processing
Student 4, Age 20	Caucasian	Rural	Self-contained class, unpaid internship in community	Community college 1 day a week	Career Planning, Culinary Arts I, Introduction to Drawing (audit), Intro to Computers
Student 5, Age 21	Caucasian	Rural	Self-contained class, unpaid internship in community	Community college 1 day a week	Career Planning, First Aid and CPR (audit), Intro to Computers
Student 6, Age 20	Caucasian	Rural	Self-contained class, paid work in community	Community college 3 days a week	Intro to Human Services, Baking Theory, Basic Drawing, Computer Applications
Student 7, Age 20	Caucasian	Rural	Self-contained class	Community college 3 days a week	Fundamentals of Acting, Yoga, Aerobics 1 & 2, Physical Conditioning, Career Planning
Student 8, Age 21	Caucasian	Rural	No school, paid work in community 2 days a week	Community college 3 days a week	Intro to Geology & Earth (audit), Career Development, Stagecraft (audit), Intro to Theatre, Movement for Actors
Student 9, Age 19	African American	Urban	Self-contained class 1 day a week; paid work in community 2 days a week	Community college 2 days a week	Intro to Computers, Sociology for Men

paramount from the start (Phelps, Fisher, & Ellis, 2007). Images with related narratives and audio recordings were identified as multimodality data (Halverson, 2010) and were analyzed as a whole to draw appropriate conclusions (Banks, 2007; Pink, 2007). After a data analysis process described below, two member checks for understanding were conducted. The first was with students at the final meeting with each of them. The second was with a selected group of professional staff who were familiar with inclusive concurrent enrollment practices.

Data Analysis Process

A modified grounded theory analysis (Creswell, 1994; Strauss & Corbin, 1998) was used to identify and develop concepts that theoretically explain a social phenomenon, in this case, attending college. Grounded theory holds that theories should be "grounded" from the field, especially in the way that individuals interact, take action, or engage in a process in response to a phenomenon. After collecting data from multiple sources (i.e., meetings, photographs, video clips, comments) and over multiple visits (February–October 2009), the researcher followed a process of (a) open coding, in which codes were formed by reviewing the students' data, expressions, and vocabulary to describe college; (b) axial coding to review the codes and to associate multiple definitions to their codes, and then (c) selective coding to write a story line. Then data, codes, and research facilitator's field notes were uploaded onto NU*DIST, qualitative software to sort through the coded work. A data display matrix helped find relationships among themes in a form that worked to reduce data and to present it as a whole (Miles & Huberman, 1994; Strauss & Corbin, 1998).

Training Student Researchers

The student researchers were asked to complete six phases of research activity beginning in January 2009. The phases included the following:

Table 2. Student Discussion on Six Themes

Theme	Things They Like	Their Recommendations for Improvements
Having a new identity and feeling different	Having independence on campus	Having more opportunities to take college courses
	Choosing your own schedule	
	Being yourself or reinventing yourself; college can be "reset button"	
	Being with other college students	
	Becoming an educated person	
Access to different classes	Having access to very different courses from those offered in high school	Having opportunities to talk to other students about classes before enrolling in them
	Having a greater selection of courses	Having more access to classes tied to career interests
	Taking classes at various times and in multiple ways (face to face, online)	Having more sections of classes offered
	Taking classes that help discover strengths and preferences	Having support to take night and weekend classes
Adjusting to new expectations	Being treated like an adult	Being better prepared for college specifically in:
	Learning to take responsibility for yourself	Understanding expectations for students before going to college
	Trying things in college; being less scared	Knowing how to organize for classes
		Being familiar with college terms: "syllabus," "due date," "reading assignment"
Working with educational coaches	Having an educational coach who helps you settle in, learn to get around campus, and figure out assignments	Being given independence and trust to take courses and participate in campus activities, and asking for help when needed from the coach
Campus life	Hanging out on campus	Spending more time on campus
	Using computers at library to check email and use social media websites	Having more strategies to develop friends with other students
	Using recreation facilities to work out and take fitness classes	
	Having opportunities to hang out at student center and join clubs	
	Meeting friends at cafeteria	
Transportation	Using public transportation	More transportation options in rural areas
	Using college shuttle	

1. *Document:* Students documented their college experience with digital cameras or pocket video cameras. The research facilitator asked them to describe their college experience, which aspects of college they viewed as strengths of the experience, and what recommendations they have for improvement. Based on these questions, students took more than 250 photos and video clips.
2. *Share:* Since students were geographically dispersed across Massachusetts, they shared their work with each other online using their own private VoiceThread, a password-protected online service that allows users to upload materials and share them with others.
3. *Discuss:* Using various feedback options of VoiceThread, students posted nearly 300 comments using a keyboard, phone, webcam, or computer microphone. Through this forum, students were able to share their own issues as well as learn about issues that vary throughout the state, such as transportation needs.
4. *Recommend:* Students worked together to make recommendations they believed would help improve the college experience. To address the challenge highlighted by K. Ward and Trigler (2001), that individuals with ID may be challenged to extrapolate meaning beyond their own experience, the research facilitator worked with each student to physically manipulate printed copies of the photos and comments into categories. Once each student determined themes, the research facilitator shared how fellow students had arranged them. This process continued until students agreed on a final set of themes. Table 2 represents a consensus of student comments on these themes.

5. *Act:* Students decided on action steps that they could take as a result of their work. Recommendations for further steps are described in more detail below.
6. *Reflect:* Students reflected about the research and decided what else needed to be done. One student concluded, "I think it would help students to do [research] projects like this. Some people think going to college is a waste of time and I tell them it's not. This gives me a chance to show people it's a good idea."

Results

Student PAR Results

Students completed the PAR cycle over two semesters. The following summarizes how they described their college experience, which aspects of college they viewed as strengths of the experience, and what recommendations they have for improvement. Following these results is the research facilitators' analysis based on the students' data as well as her field notes and observations.

Summary of Themes

Six major themes evolved from students' work that addressed both what they liked and their recommendations. Two themes—"having a new identity and feeling different" and "adjusting to new expectations"—described an awareness students have about how the postsecondary experience is influencing them personally. Two other themes, "access to different classes" and "transportation," addressed issues of access, independence, and new learning. The other two themes, "working with educational coaches" and "campus life," addressed new relationships, new routines, and self-determination. In each theme, students discussed what was making college successful and made suggestions for improvement.

Having a new identity and feeling different. All students reported feeling freer at college and particularly appreciated having schedules that included not just classes but also time to socialize. Many felt this flexibility contributed to their feelings of being more mature. As one student summarized, "It's a time to set the reset button on your life." Another student concluded that one of the best things about being in college is becoming an educated person.

Access to different classes. Students reported that course selection was much larger in college than it was in high school and that there were more options to take classes at different times of the day. According to students, taking college courses helped them discover or demonstrate their strengths. Students made a few recommendations for improvement, including (a) giving students opportunities to talk to other students about classes before enrolling in them and (b) obtaining access to more classes related to their career interests. For those who wanted to take evening or weekend courses, a challenge was finding the education and travel support needed, and several students noted the need to find a solution to this problem.

Adjusting to new expectations. Students agreed that first-year college students need to be prepared for more responsibility and people's higher expectations. As several students said, "People treat you like an adult." Students pointed out that not only were courses different than the high school but they included a lot of homework and lots of assignments. Among the comments students posted on the VoiceThread were the following:

- You have to study and read a lot.
- In college the professors don't baby you like they do in high school. You're responsible for your own work.
- In college, you need to know how to read a syllabus and organize your own work.

Despite the challenges of taking college courses, students agreed that they did get used to meeting higher expectations. They recommended first-year students get organized with college supplies and a day planner (electronic or book); be familiar with terms used in college like *syllabus*, *reading assignments*, *due dates*; and record all the due dates from the syllabus and "talk to your professor if you are having a problem." About homework, one student suggested, "Take your time to do your homework. Don't rush through it." Another said, "I wasn't sure I could do the work in college. Then, I just decided I could and got help from my professor. I'm fine."

Working with educational coaches. All students had experience working with an educational coach at college. For the most part, students felt that it was very helpful to have someone on campus who could help new students learn how to get around. Some students said that having a coach helped them get used to reading their syllabus and organizing their homework. Several students agreed that "the coaches are good to help you settle in." However, some of the students also agreed that coaches sometimes gave more help than students really needed. One student suggested that from the start, students should do homework on their own, and if they need to, they can ask their educational coach for help. Students from two colleges felt that although they appreciated their coaches, having the coaches made them feel like they were being babied if the coaches gave them too much help. Three students agreed that you have to learn to do college work on your own. As one student said, "I'd like to learn things on my own."

Table 3. Student Recommendations for Students Considering College

Considerations	Recommendations
For students who are not sure if college is right for them . . .	Come talk to us or to other students you know who have gone to college. Visit colleges and take a tour.
When selecting a class . . .	Talk to other students who have taken a class you are interested in to hear what it is like. Start with a simple class. Take an Orientation to College and Career class so you can figure out what you like.
Working with educational coaches . . .	Figure out how to work together. Take responsibility for yourself and ask your education coach for help only when you need it. Remember, educational coaches can't help you with everything.
Doing college work . . .	Be prepared and get all your supplies before the course starts. Get ready for lots of reading and homework. You have to learn that college is harder than high school but it will get easier. Talk to somebody like your professor when you need help. Remember that you can go to Disability Services for help. Remember that you are responsible for your own work. College professors won't baby you—read the syllabus and ask for help if you need it. Take your time with homework—don't rush through it.
Hanging out on campus . . .	Make time to go to the cafeteria, student center, fitness center, and library. Make time to just have fun on campus, even if it's just hanging out with people.
Tips for starting new friendships with classmates or students you meet on campus . . .	Invite them to have lunch with you in the cafeteria. Ask them about the classes they are taking. Offer to exchange email addresses so you can stay in touch. Ask them what they think about the college you are both attending.

Campus life. In reviewing images posted on VoiceThread, students determined they all appreciated having time on campus to do other things besides taking classes. Students indicated during their first semester they usually just went to class and then had lunch at the cafeteria. As they became more familiar with campus, they liked having time to go to the library to check their email and use the Internet to get on sports websites, sign into social media, or fill out online job applications. Several students posted images of themselves using the recreation center because they appreciated having access to a gym and fitness classes. Several students said one of the best differences between high school and college was the freedom they had to hang out between classes. Among areas for improvement, students recommended finding ways for students to stay on campus longer and figuring out how students can get more support to attend evening and weekend events. Some students said having strategies to begin new friendships at college would be helpful as well.

Transportation. A common theme among students was how to take public transportation to college. Students came from urban, suburban, and rural communities and were using a wide range of transportation options. For those students in cities, they were learning to use the city buses and subway trains. Some students were using paratransit services and were learning to call in for their own transportation pickups to and from college. Students in the suburbs were using a combination of subways, buses, and college shuttle vans to get to campus. Students from rural communities were using paratransit services if available. The primary theme of using transportation was learning to accept responsibility for using public transportation and adjusting to the unpredictability that comes with it. All students agreed that it was important to know how to use public transportation and anticipate delays. The primary recommendation for improvement came from students living in rural communities who suggested that more travel options are necessary for them to get to college.

Student Recommendations

Based on the documentation shared on VoiceThread, students had many recommendations for potential college students that are highlighted in Table 3.

After learning about how research findings are typically shared, during Phase 5: Act, students identified ways to share their research and take action, including the following:

- Presenting their information to the advisory committee of a college access initiative, the advisory board that oversees a consortium of postsecondary education initiatives
- Making recommendations for improving the "For Students" section of the Think College website, developed by a national center for postsecondary education opportunities for students with ID
- Presenting their work to younger students in high school and middle school
- Developing digital stories about their college experiences and posting them on the Think College website
- Presenting their research at local conferences and to local advocacy groups
- Writing articles to publish and post on a college access website

Discussion

PAR has the potential to serve as an effective and accessible research method for individuals with ID pursuing postsecondary education. As a strategy to gain information from students about their experiences and perceptions of college, it could be used to augment or supplement traditional research approaches such as national surveys. More specifically, it is useful when national surveys inadvertently exclude students with ID either because they are enrolled in nontraditional programs or because the surveys are inaccessible to them. This PAR study, in combination with digital media tools for data collection, produced data that align with information gathered from other national college surveys. Information garnered included data on first-year student adjustment to college expectations, connections with other people on campus, and level of participation in campuswide activities. In addition, the study involved students gathering their own data that they themselves chose to discuss. This important information highlighted such things as the steep learning curve students faced to learn college terminology, to take responsibility for themselves, and to adjust to expectations previously assumed by others (e.g., teaching assistants, parents) but now expected of them as college students. This information is important not only for colleges to understand but also for students themselves to communicate to others.

An overarching finding from the PAR study was seen through the students' images and stories about their inclusive college experiences. They revealed their own insights into how college is influencing their lives. In several ways, they were describing their college experience as an opportunity to reinvent themselves as young adults who were part of an academic and social community. As members of this community, they felt they were held to the same expectations as everyone else, acknowledging that sometimes these expectations were hard to live up to. Both high school transition staff and college staff can benefit from listening to these college students who likely experienced high school very differently than college. Findings from conducting PAR with the students touch on identity development, academic engagement and reflection, persistence, and support. The following sections discuss each finding.

Identity Development

Students used terms such as *mature*, *different*, and *like everyone else* to describe differences they felt about themselves after a semester of college. Through their images and comments, they described themselves as being held to new and higher expectations. For example, when students described being treated "like an adult," they inferred this was different from how it was in high school. To make this point, some students shared examples of their professors' expectations that college students do their work without being reminded, and other students reported that they blended in on the campus in a way they did not in high school. One student described "fitting in" as a college student instead of as a student in a separate classroom at the high school. Arnett (2004) described college participation as an important phase of identity development in what he called "emerging adulthood" and said that going to college is an experience that allows students to explore many identities. Pascarella and Terenzini (1991) described this growth as one of the nonacademic benefits college students experience as well as developing academic values, developing a more distinct academic identity, and becoming more confident socially. In addition, they described an improvement in students' self-concepts and psychological well-being.

Academic Engagement and Reflection

Students' research also indicated that they were learning and retaining content from their academic classes. Several students in this study described philosophical, historical, and abstract concepts they learned in their college classes as well as differing perspectives. Arnett (2007) attributed the development of reflective judgment and critical thinking, in part, to college attendance and specifically to conversations in college classes that prompt critical thinking. In addition, students reflected on their high school curriculum and indicated that, compared to their high school work, college courses were more accessible, interesting, and rigorous. As one student put it, "This class is about and for men. It's sociology.

It's not something I could have ever taken in high school." Addressing the rigor, another student said, "You think in high school you're taking a hard class. Then you come to college. These are hard classes."

Persistence

Students also described the adjustment needed to respond to higher expectations. They described having to learn to do harder work and speak up when they need help. For many, this meant talking to professors and, in some cases, classmates. Scanlon, Rowling, and Weber (2007) indicated that this experience of building relationships with instructors and peers influenced growth of a new identity. Their persistence to proceed despite challenges compares to that of their college peers without disabilities. Traditional college students need to adapt to new ways to learn in college, and in doing so, they develop skills to become more independent learners. Anctil, Ishikawa, and Scott (2008) describe this as a developing academic identity that results from persistence. Many students in this study indicated that they now identified as college students and that college students have to be prepared for hard work.

Support

Students discussed the educational support they had at college, and in many ways the issues they addressed mimic issues that occur in K–12 settings. Students appreciated the support, especially at the beginning of their first semester when they were learning to navigate the campus, enrolling in their classes, organizing their college work, and discussing their accommodations with instructors. However, as students adjusted to these new responsibilities, some discussed the fact that even after they no longer need the support, some educational coaches were giving them help.

Students indicated that this made them feel overprotected. This support has been described as "excessive support" in the K–12 literature (Giangreco & Broer, 2005) and can lead to unnecessary dependence, stigmatization, interference with peer interactions, interference with instructor involvement, and less competent instruction (Causton-Theoharis, 2009; Giangreco & Broer, 2005). As a result, students' K–12 school experiences can include feelings of embarrassment, stigmatization, and loneliness (Broer, Doyle, & Giangreco, 2005). The individual support model, which was recommended on these campuses, was, in fact, not based on a K–12 model of support but instead based on a supported education model of instruction. In this model, which has it roots in supporting students with psychiatric disabilities (Mowbray et al., 2005), student support includes increasing individual skills, increasing support from the environment, and maximizing the fit between an individual and his or her environment. Principals of universal design, self-determination, supported risk taking, and faded support frame the inclusive postsecondary education model. Students in this study reported feeling independent and free while at the same time also feeling overprotected on the college campus.

Limitations

There are a number of limitations to this study. First, the sample size was small, as only nine students participated in the study. In addition, the study represents only one state's postsecondary education initiative. As a result, it is not possible to make any generalizations to students beyond those involved in the ICE initiative. In addition, conducting a PAR study with college students with ID requires much more time and staff resources than do traditional methods. The PAR tool kits, although simple, required funding to purchase multimedia equipment. The most expensive item, the pocket video camera, cost between \$125.00 and \$145.00. Replicating this work would require a commitment from at least one researcher to meet with students at their convenience. This can be a challenge for the research facilitator when meeting with concurrently enrolled college students, who are often balancing college, work, and travel schedules. Facilitating a PAR project takes time and energy from the research facilitator and student researchers. Other qualitative research methodologies such as focus groups, surveys, and even case studies could have been completed in less time and would have yielded equally important information from students about their college experience.

Implications for Practice

Facilitating PAR with individuals with ID has the potential to expose researchers and practitioners to information and insights they would not obtain easily using other research methods. Giving individuals the time, tools, instructions, and guidance to document information that directly pertains to their own lives and experiences allows them to engage in research in ways that are more accessible and relevant than methods shown to be challenging for them (Finlay & Lyons, 2002; Heller et al., 1996). As a result, researchers and practitioners can draw more accurate conclusions with individuals about what is going well and what needs to change to be more responsive to their needs and concerns. Since PAR is a flexible method that does not dictate a specific strategy, PAR methods can augment other research strategies, such as focus groups and surveys, and also could be used with faculty members, disability services staff, adult providers, and school staff. By using digital tools, data are accessible to all stakeholders. PAR is especially useful for anyone who is seeking to evaluate activities or experiences *with* participants rather than *for* participants.

More importantly, there are many potential benefits to individuals themselves who may feel acknowledged and empowered by the opportunity to collaborate on research rather than be the recipients of it. The PAR process itself serves as a tool for individuals with ID to reflect on their experiences and discuss them with others. Individuals may find that digital tools can help to better explain experiences and to recommend solutions. Finally, individuals with ID may benefit from the process itself through working closely with one or more people who are encouraging them to speak up—through words, images, and actions.

Conclusion

Taking the time to collaborate with students to research their college experience provides a rich opportunity to hear from students about the benefits of college and to listen to their recommendations for improvement. Digital storytelling and the use of digital media tools are two strategies that give students with ID the ability to describe their experiences themselves.

As a result of this research, students and the research facilitator have used the findings to develop a Think College Research to Practice (Paiewonsky, Sroka, Ahearn, et al., 2010). brief, present the findings to the ICE partners, and discuss the initiative at state conferences. Equally important, students' findings have assisted trainers to adjust and develop new training materials for students, parents, and professionals. Topics include (a) working with educational coaches, (b) preparing for academic advising, (c) learning to use public transportation to attend college, and (d) making a college career connection.

Working directly with students to conduct research on how new educational opportunities are influencing their lives sheds light on student perspectives and experiences that would not be available in any other format. Looking together at photographs and video clips gives staff a way to discuss and understand how policies and practices are positively or negatively influencing students' education and lives on campus. Having these authentic data gives staff the ability to create meaningful training materials and provide technical assistance to better meet the needs of college students who are in many ways pioneering their way in college.

The PAR model allows coresearchers to mutually benefit from the process. For students with ID, collaborating in PAR gives them an opportunity to work with researchers who can share their knowledge of action research. As a result, students can build an awareness of inquiry, reflection, and action in a direct and meaningful way. Learning to use multimedia tools gives students the chance to learn and apply technology and visual research skills that can help them articulate their opinions and concerns in the future, especially for students with reading and writing challenges. Armed with these skills, students can make suggestions to improve the college experience. The PAR process gives students the opportunity to reflect on this new experience and, most importantly, allows students with ID a leadership role in shaping an inclusive college education.

Declaration of Conflicting Interests

The author(s) declared no potential conflicts of interests with respect to the authorship and/or publication of this article.

Financial Disclosure/Funding

The author(s) received no financial support for the research and/or authorship of this article.

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